

HowZombiesWork.com — Site Vision, Story, and Architecture

Working subtitle: *A field guide to the infection already inside the house.*

Purpose: Convert the zombie curiosity hook into a cinematic, readable, non-preachy cautionary tale about self-witnessing as cure.

1. Executive Vision

HowZombiesWork.com should look, at first glance, like a clever zombie explainer site: cinematic, funny, graphic-novel-adjacent, curious, slightly pulpy, and safe for a broad audience. Visitors arrive expecting zombies eating brains, survival tips, infection lore, and maybe a playful pop-horror parody.

That expectation should be honored. The site should begin with visible zombies, genre language, infection metaphors, field-guide framing, and cartoonish menace. But as the visitor scrolls, the site gradually reveals that the zombie outbreak is not merely fictional. It is already happening as a psychological, social, algorithmic, emotional, and consent-based infection.

The core reveal:

Zombies are other people until you see the zombie in you.

The cure:

Radical self-acceptance restores self-witnessing. Self-witnessing restores choice. Choice restores consent. Consent revocation ends the infection.

The site is not a sermon. It is a story-machine. It uses horror-comedy as a lure, then turns the mirror gently. The visitor should feel amused, intrigued, implicated, softened, and then invited into agency.

2. Core Thesis

Primary thesis

A zombie is a person whose behavior has outrun their self-witnessing.

Supporting thesis

When a person cannot witness what is moving through them, they become available to be moved by something else.

Cure thesis

You are not cured when the hunger disappears. You are cured when you can witness the hunger without obeying it.

Consent thesis

If you can witness the force moving you, you can revoke consent to being operated by it.

3. Tone and Genre

The site should occupy a very specific tonal lane:

- **Shaun of the Dead-esque** in the sense of social comedy plus zombie absurdity.
- **Public health field guide** in the sense of symptom lists, transmission pathways, and cure protocols.
- **Graphic novel** in the sense of panels, visual reveals, cinematic compositions, expressive faces, and poster-like section breaks.
- **Pop-readable** in the sense of short paragraphs, clear sequencing, high scanability, and emotional accessibility.
- **Spiritual without sounding spiritual** in the sense that radical acceptance and self-witnessing are embedded as survival mechanics, not doctrine.

The reader should not feel preached at. They should feel like they are discovering that the zombie genre was always a mirror.

4. Audience Journey

The site should move visitors through five psychological states.

1. Curiosity

They arrive because zombies are fun. The site gives them zombies immediately.

Emotional state: "This looks cool."

Design mode: cinematic, funny, dark, cartoony.

2. Recognition of others

They begin identifying zombie-like behavior in the world around them: outrage, imitation, herding, compulsive reaction, attention hunger.

Emotional state: "Yes, people are like this."

Design mode: satirical, observational, humorous.

3. Mirror turn

The site reveals that the infection is not limited to “other people.” It appears wherever witnessing stops.

Emotional state: “Oh. I do this too.”

Design mode: slower, darker, reflective, cinematic.

4. Humanization

The visitor is reassured that infection is not moral failure. It is unwitnessed movement. Shame worsens the condition.

Emotional state: “I am not bad. I am being invited to notice.”

Design mode: warmer, calmer, less jagged.

5. Agency

The cure is introduced as a practice: notice, allow, revoke. The visitor is offered a way out that preserves dignity.

Emotional state: “I can interrupt this.”

Design mode: dawn, clarity, spaciousness, choice.

5. Narrative Spine

The entire homepage should behave like a movie trailer that becomes a self-recognition ritual.

Act I — The Outbreak

The visitor sees zombies as external monsters. They are funny, alarming, and familiar. The site explains zombie traits in exaggerated, cartoonish terms.

Key question: **What do zombies want?**

Act II — The Mechanism

The site explains that the bite is only symbolic. The real infection moves through unwitnessed reaction, borrowed narrative, herd synchronization, and consent collapse.

Key question: **How does the infection spread?**

Act III — The Mirror

The site reveals that zombies are not a separate category of people. Zombie-state is a condition that can arise in anyone when behavior outruns self-witnessing.

Key question: **Where does the zombie appear in me?**

Act IV — The Cure

The site teaches that radical self-acceptance is not indulgence. It is the condition that makes self-witnessing possible. Self-witnessing creates enough separation to revoke consent from the operating force.

Key question: **Can I witness the hunger without obeying it?**

Act V — Return to Humanity

The site lands in dignity. The visitor is not the infection. If they can witness it, they are already partly free.

Key question: **What do I no longer consent to being operated by?**

6. Homepage Architecture

Section 1 — Hero: The Outbreak Has Already Happened

Goal: Satisfy zombie curiosity immediately while planting unease.

Headline:

The Outbreak Has Already Happened.

Subheadline:

They told you zombies eat brains. That was only half true.

Visual:

A cinematic cartoon street scene at dusk. Zombies shuffle through a recognizably modern world: phones, suburbs, offices, comment sections, classrooms, traffic, shopping carts, family dinners. The image should be funny before it is disturbing.

Possible hero microcopy:

A non-graphic field guide to the infection already moving through ordinary life.

Primary CTA:

Start the Field Guide

Secondary CTA:

Check Yourself for Symptoms

Design notes:

- Slight fog/parallax.
 - Flickering streetlight.
 - One zombie staring too directly at the viewer.
 - No gore. The menace is vacancy, hunger, and loss of agency.
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Section 2 — What Zombies Want

Goal: Let the visitor externalize first. This creates the bait.

Headline:

What Zombies Want

Intro copy:

Zombies do not merely chase bodies. They chase signals. Attention. Agreement. Reaction. Certainty. Anything that makes the hunger feel briefly organized.

Cards/panels:

Zombies Crave Attention

They are not full. They are trying to become real by being noticed.

Zombies Move in Herds

Not because they agree, but because they cannot self-orient.

Zombies Repeat Signals

Catchphrases. Outrage. Scripts. Certainty. The words keep moving after the witness has left.

Zombies Do Not Know They Are Zombies

This is the dangerous part.

Section 3 — The Bite Was Never the Point

Goal: Pivot from monster lore to mechanism.

Headline:

The Bite Was Never the Point.

Copy:

The classic zombie bite is a metaphor for a deeper mechanism: contact without witnessing. A signal enters. A reaction fires. A self disappears.

Mechanism strip:

Trigger → Reaction → Identification → Repetition → Herding → Loss of Consent

Panel sequence:

1. A signal lands.
 2. The body reacts.
 3. The mind explains the reaction.
 4. The explanation becomes identity.
 5. Identity seeks a herd.
 6. The person acts without feeling choice.
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Section 4 — Mirror Reveal

Goal: Execute the central turn.

Headline beat 1:

Zombies are other people.

Scroll beat / reveal:

Until you see the zombie in you.

Visual:

A person looks through a barricaded window at zombies outside. As the scroll continues, the glass reflection reveals their own face carrying subtle zombie traits: dull eyes, clenched jaw, phone glow, slogan mouth, hungry posture, panic grip.

Copy restraint:

Keep this section minimal. The mirror should do the work.

Section 5 — Symptoms of Infection

Goal: Make self-recognition concrete without shame.

Headline:

Common Symptoms

Intro copy:

Infection does not begin when you become bad. It begins when something moves through you faster than you can witness it.

Symptom cards:

Compulsion

"I had to respond."

Self-witnessing cue: What would happen if I did not obey the urgency?

Certainty

"I already know what this means."

Self-witnessing cue: What am I protecting by being so sure?

Projection

"The problem is definitely them."

Self-witnessing cue: What part of this reaction belongs to me?

Scripted Speech

"I am saying words I did not choose."

Self-witnessing cue: Whose language is moving my mouth?

Consent Collapse

"I can feel myself doing it, but I cannot stop."

Self-witnessing cue: What force am I letting operate me?

Hunger

"I need them to agree, react, suffer, notice, submit, apologize, disappear."

Self-witnessing cue: What is the hunger underneath the hunger?

Universal reassurance line:

This does not mean you are bad. It means something in you is asking to be witnessed.

Section 6 — How Zombies Work

Goal: Deliver the promised explanatory payoff.

Headline:

How Zombies Work

Core copy:

A zombie is not a monster. A zombie is a person whose behavior has outrun their self-witnessing.

When a person cannot witness what is moving through them, they become available to be moved by something else: fear, shame, outrage, ideology, addiction, algorithmic reinforcement, group belonging, trauma, resentment, status hunger, or borrowed certainty.

Visual:

A fake medical/mechanical diagram of a zombie operating system.

Modules:

- Unwitnessed Pain
 - Threat Scanner
 - Shame Reactor
 - Borrowed Narrative
 - Herd Sync
 - Appetite Loop
 - Identity Lock
 - Consent Override
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Section 7 — Why the Infection Gets Worse

Goal: Make the cautionary tale explicit.

Headline:

Why It Gets Worse

Copy:

The infection spreads whenever an unwitnessed reaction demands participation from others.

Escalation ladder:

Stage 1 — Private Unwitnessed Reaction

"I do not know why I feel this way."

Stage 2 — External Blame

"It must be because of them."

Stage 3 — Identity Fusion

"This reaction is who I am."

Stage 4 — Herd Reinforcement

"Everyone around me agrees."

Stage 5 — Consent Death

"I no longer experience myself as choosing."

Stage 6 — Transmission

"Now I need you to carry it too."

Section 8 — Do Not Fight the Zombie

Goal: Prevent domination/shaming interpretations.

Headline:

You Cannot Shame a Zombie Back to Life.

Copy:

Shame feeds the infection. Force spreads it. Mockery hardens it. The cure begins when witnessing returns.

Secondary copy:

The goal is not to defeat the zombie. The goal is to restore the person.

Section 9 — The Cure

Goal: Introduce the clean, memorable protocol.

Headline:

The Cure Is Self-Witnessing.

Subheadline:

Radical self-acceptance restores the witness. The witness restores choice. Choice restores consent.

Protocol:

1. Notice

"What is moving in me?"

2. Allow

"Can this be here without becoming my master?"

3. Revoke

"I do not consent to be operated by this."

Core line:

You are not cured when the hunger disappears. You are cured when you can witness the hunger without obeying it.

Section 10 — Check Yourself for Symptoms

Goal: Convert insight into self-application.

Format:

A short interactive diagnostic that never shames the visitor.

Possible questions:

1. When I am triggered, do I become more curious or more certain?
2. Do I know what I am feeling before I explain who is wrong?
3. Can I pause before recruiting someone else into my reaction?
4. Am I trying to be understood, or am I trying to infect?
5. Do I still consent to the behavior I am performing?
6. What am I hungry for right now?
7. What would I be afraid to feel if I stopped reacting?

Possible result types:

- Witness Partially Online
- High Herd-Sync Detected
- Consent Override Possible
- Hunger Loop Active
- Mirror Available
- Cure Sequence Ready

Example result copy:

Hunger Loop Active. Something in you may be reaching for reaction before it has been witnessed. Pause for one minute. Ask: what is the hunger underneath this urgency? You do not have to shame it. You do not have to obey it. Witness first. Choose second.

Section 11 — The Field Manual

Goal: Create article architecture for deeper content and future expansion.

Headline:

The Field Manual

Hub intro:

The outbreak has many strains. Each one begins where witnessing stops and something else takes the wheel.

Article cards:

How Outrage Zombies Work

When moral energy loses self-witnessing.

How Shame Zombies Work

When the self tries to survive by disappearing.

How Algorithm Zombies Work

When attention becomes externally piloted.

How Relationship Zombies Work

When attachment panic overrides consent.

How Ideology Zombies Work

When belonging replaces perception.

How Productivity Zombies Work

When usefulness replaces being.

How Consumer Zombies Work

When hunger is mistaken for identity.

How Authority Zombies Work

When borrowed power replaces inner contact.

Section 12 — Final Landing: You Are Not the Infection

Goal: Land in dignity and shareability.

Headline:

You Are Not the Infection.

Copy:

Something moved through you. Something trained you. Something used your pain, your fear, your hunger, your loneliness, your need to belong.

But if you can witness it, you are not it. And if you are not it, you can revoke consent.

Final CTA:

Begin the Cure

Secondary CTA:

Share the Field Guide

Visual:

Dawn after the outbreak. Not destroyed zombies, but people waking up. Someone putting down a sign. Someone stepping away from a herd. Someone laughing gently at themselves. Someone looking in a mirror. Someone choosing not to bite.

7. Visual System

Color story

The palette should evolve with the narrative.

Opening infection palette:

- Sickly green
- Emergency red
- Midnight blue
- Black ink
- Off-white paper
- Sodium streetlight yellow

Cure palette:

- Dawn gold
- Soft cream
- Human warmth
- Moss green
- Quiet blue
- Clean white space

The site should move from infection lighting to witnessed daylight.

Typography

Use two primary typographic voices.

Display voice: cinematic, pulp-horror, poster-like, bold, slightly distressed. Use for section titles and trailer beats.

Body voice: readable, warm, modern, calm. Use for explanation and protocol language.

Avoid making everything horror-styled. Horror is the wrapper; clarity is the payload.

Illustration style

The best direction is:

- Thick ink outlines
- Expressive cartoon faces
- Cinematic framing
- Limited gore
- Exaggerated posture
- Funny background details
- Occasional serious close-ups
- Graphic novel panels without making the reading experience niche

The zombies should become emotionally more complex over time:

1. Funny
2. Annoying
3. Sad
4. Familiar
5. Human

8. Motion and Interaction

Use motion as atmosphere, not clutter.

Recommended motion moments:

- Slow parallax fog in the hero.
- Flickering streetlights.
- Comic panels sliding gently into place.
- Infection meter rising during the mechanism section.
- Mirror reveal below the fold.
- Cursor hover that makes zombies briefly look at the visitor.
- Red alert UI gradually becoming calm witness UI.
- The cure section breathing: more space, less jitter, softer transitions.

Avoid excessive jump scares. The site is not horror for horror's sake. The real scare is recognition.

9. Content Architecture Beyond Homepage

Primary pages

Home

The cinematic story path and central conversion experience.

Field Manual

A hub for zombie strain articles.

Check Yourself

Interactive self-witnessing diagnostic.

The Cure

A deeper but still readable explanation of radical self-acceptance, self-witnessing, choice, and consent revocation.

Transmission

A page about how unwitnessed states spread through families, feeds, groups, institutions, and movements.

About

Explain the project without over-explaining the metaphysics. Emphasize cautionary tale, public self-witnessing, and non-shaming restoration of agency.

Field Manual article template

Each article should follow this pattern:

1. **Zombie cold open** — funny, cinematic, specific.
 2. **Symptoms** — recognizable behaviors.
 3. **What is actually happening** — mechanism.
 4. **How it spreads** — transmission.
 5. **Where it appears in me** — mirror.
 6. **Witnessing practice** — one practical cue.
 7. **Consent revocation phrase** — simple language.
 8. **Human return** — no shame, restore dignity.
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10. Key Copy Bank

Taglines

- The infection already happened.
- A field guide to the outbreak inside ordinary life.
- Zombies are other people until you see the zombie in you.
- The cure is not violence. The cure is witnessing.
- Don't fight the zombie. Restore the witness.
- If you can witness it, you are not it.
- Revoke consent from the thing operating you.

Anchor lines

- A zombie is a person whose behavior has outrun their self-witnessing.
- The bite was never the point.
- Contact without witnessing is how the infection spreads.
- Shame feeds the infection.
- Force spreads it.
- Mockery hardens it.
- The goal is not to defeat the zombie. The goal is to restore the person.
- You are not cured when the hunger disappears. You are cured when you can witness the hunger without obeying it.
- If you can witness the force moving you, you can revoke consent to being operated by it.

Consent revocation phrases

- I do not consent to be operated by this urgency.
 - I do not consent to outsource my perception to the herd.
 - I do not consent to let shame drive my body.
 - I do not consent to make another person carry my unwitnessed reaction.
 - I do not consent to confuse hunger with truth.
 - I do not consent to become less human in order to feel safe.
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11. Design Principles

1. Give them zombies first

Do not start with the lesson. Start with the genre promise.

2. Make the metaphor fun before making it true

The visitor needs to enjoy the frame before they are asked to see themselves in it.

3. Never shame the reader

The infection is serious, but shame worsens it. Every hard recognition should be paired with dignity.

4. Keep the mirror gradual

Do not accuse. Reveal.

5. Make the cure incredibly simple

Notice. Allow. Revoke.

6. Let the visual tone transform

The site should feel like moving from night to dawn.

7. Preserve broad applicability

Do not let the zombie metaphor become partisan, class-coded, or targeted at one obvious outgroup.

8. Make it shareable

The site should contain memorable lines, panels, quizzes, and article cards that can travel as memes.

12. Build Notes / Practical Implementation

Suggested stack

A static-first site is likely sufficient for v1:

- Astro, Next.js, or plain HTML/CSS/JS.
- Markdown-based Field Manual articles.
- Lightweight quiz logic client-side.
- SVG or optimized illustrated panels.
- CSS-driven scroll animations where possible.

MVP scope

For a strong first launch:

1. Homepage story path.
2. Simple symptom checker.
3. Field Manual hub with 3 initial articles.
4. About page.
5. Shareable graphics or quote panels.

Initial Field Manual articles

Recommended first three:

1. How Outrage Zombies Work
2. How Shame Zombies Work
3. How Algorithm Zombies Work

These give the site immediate cultural relevance while staying nonpartisan and self-reflective.

13. The Site in One Breath

HowZombiesWork.com begins as a funny, cinematic zombie field guide and slowly reveals that the real outbreak is the spread of unwitnessed reaction through people, groups, feeds, and institutions. A zombie is not a monster, but a person whose behavior has outrun their self-witnessing. The cure is radical self-acceptance, because only what can be accepted can be witnessed, and only what can be witnessed can be disidentified from, chosen around, and consent-revoked. The visitor enters laughing at zombies and leaves with a practical mirror: what is moving in me, and do I still consent to let it operate me?